

Here's how to keep those unexpected repairs as low as possible:

1. DO-IT-YOURSELF

When something goes wrong, you can either call in an expert, or attempt to fix it yourself. Most of us tend to gravitate towards the latter, as the DIY route is typically viewed as the most budget-friendly option. And when you look at current labor costs, that's mostly true. It's hard to justify spending that money on a professional when you may have the skills needed to fix the problem yourself...and for much less!

READER TIP:

With our condo, we had recurring plumbing problems and every time we had to fork out €150 just for a plumber to show up. We got fed up with it and bought a plumbers spring to fix it ourselves. Saved us at least €500 and the spring cost a mere €10.

—Monique, Netherlands

We recently did this when the heating elements in our hot water heater rusted out from hard water. We could have called a plumber for \$60 an hour, and crossed our fingers that he'd finish the job in that amount of time, or we could buy an \$8 tool along with \$22 worth of replacement parts, and attempt it ourselves. It actually only took Joseph two hours to complete the job, saving us at least \$30.

If you don't know the exact steps to make a repair, but are pretty sure you or someone in your household has the skills to figure it out, don't be afraid to do a quick search on Google or YouTube for detailed instructions. There are thousands of tutorials available to guide you through almost any DIY attempt.

2. LEARN YOUR LIMITS

Being able to DIY is great, but you have to know your limits too. There are some things you simply won't be able to do yourself, and will cost a lot